

INVENTORY · STACK · STRUCTURE

principles

Declared statements — short stated principles, each with a one-line justification.

How we make calls when the spec is silent.

- 01 Default to the choice that is cheaper to reverse.
- 02 Name the actor, never the system.
- 03 Write the bet on the same slide as the choice.
- 04 Disagree in the room, then commit outside it.
- 05 Optimise for the reader who wasn't there.

How we resolve conflicts — top wins.

- 01 Default to the choice that is cheaper to reverse.

- 02 Name the actor, never the system.

- 03 Write the bet on the same slide as the choice.

- 04 Let form follow function.

- 05 Keep one main idea per slide.

How we make calls when the spec is silent.

- A** Default to the choice that is cheaper to reverse.

- B** Name the actor, never the system.

- C** Write the bet on the same slide as the choice.

- D** Let form follow function.

- E** Keep one main idea per slide.

The editorial canon.

I Plain words beat clever ones.

II One claim per sentence.

III Show the number, then the verdict.

IV Cut the adverb, keep the verb.

V End on the decision, not the summary.

What we optimise for, in no particular order.

- Reversibility over consensus — make the cheap-to-undo call now.

- Clarity over completeness — one true thing beats five hedged ones.

- Ownership over process — processes don't get paged.

- Evidence over instinct — write the prediction down so it can be scored.

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When NOT to reach for principles.

Aspirations, not principles. "Be empathetic" is a value, not a principle. Principles are decision rules — they say what to do when two options conflict. Reach for content if it's a values statement.

Long per-principle prose. Each justification is one sentence. If a principle needs a paragraph of context, give it its own slide and let principles act as the index.

Hedged statements. "We try to default to X" reads as a wish. Drop the hedge — principles are declared, not negotiated. "Default to X" lands harder.

See also.

RELATED COMPONENTS

- `actors` — rules attach to named owners, not shared tenets
- `tldr` — single-line takeaways without justification body
- `list` — items are short bullets without title + body shape
- `cards-stack` — each principle needs two sentences of body